

Sandra George Was Underground Twice, and Only One of

A festival that calls itself a celebration of the underground can only mean one kind of underground, and it is worth working out which.

Edinburgh Art Festival is on right now, all across the city, and every review of it uses the same word: hidden. Hidden stories, secret histories, undiscovered archives. The critic writes that you can't walk into a gallery without learning about some lost genius. I read that line three times. Not the sentiment. The verb.

Walk into a gallery. Follow your nose. Sniff out something you like. The whole festival is described as a body moving freely through space — one venue to the next, up Calton Hill, out to Jupiter Artland among the horses and goats, down to Custom Lane for the erotic prints. Discovery here is a spontaneous physical act. You wander, you stumble, you uncover. The reviewer even says he feels like Columbo, which is a joke about a man who walks around noticing things.

I started out thinking this was the whole problem. An arts culture that treats cultural discovery as ambulatory has built a definition of the underground that excludes anyone whose body does not do spontaneous multi-venue wandering. Case closed. Columbo would be proud.

Then I read about Sandra George and had to put the argument down.

Sandra George was a Black photographer who documented Craigmillar, one of the poorest parts of Edinburgh, in the 1980s and 90s. She photographed protest groups working out of living rooms, people in hostels, skinheads, labourers, Hare Krishnas, kids playing in bleak places. She never showed the work publicly in her lifetime. She died in 2013, and only then was she discovered. Her show at the City Art Gallery is full of self-portraits with her young son.

Here is what stopped me. The festival's definition of underground — never shown, discovered after death — is not a metaphor about walking. It is literal. Sandra George was underground in the sense that no institution looked while she was alive. That is a real exclusion, and it has nothing to do with staircases. My tidy point about ambulatory metaphors was about to walk straight over a dead woman's actual life.

So I sat with it. What I noticed is that there are two undergrounds in that gallery and the festival can only see one.

The first underground is the archive. Work that exists, that is complete, that simply went unseen because the person who made it was Black, or poor, or a woman, or all three. The festival is genuinely good at this underground. It goes looking. It digs. Frank Walter, the Antiguan painter

who died in 2009 having never shown a single one of his thousands of paintings — the festival put his weird little cardboard rainbows next to a Lynette Yiadom-Boakye and let them win. That is real work, done well.

The second underground is the one where the work was never made at all. Where the mind that would have made it was told, early and repeatedly, that its way of seeing was a symptom.

I keep returning to a man I heard about, Deaf, told for years at school that he was bad at maths. Then he stood at a till one day, real money, real change, a real person waiting, and after a few months he was astonished at his own speed. The institutions had not found a weakness in him. They had tuned themselves to keep him away from anything that felt like friction, tracked him toward what he was already good at, and called the result support. He was not bad at maths. He had been optimised away from ever finding out.

That is the underground the festival cannot excavate, because it produces no archive to discover after death. There is no shoebox of negatives. There is a person who was told their pattern-obsession was a disorder and who therefore never built the taxonomy, never finished the map, never made the thing. You cannot mount a posthumous retrospective of work that a diagnosis prevented from existing.

I know this shape from the inside. I was told at nineteen that the way I hold a system in my head — the full-body quiet when a dataset finally resolves, hands going still — is a condition. The label was not wrong. The dataset was always there. But the label arrives attached to a verdict, and the verdict is that this is a deficit to be managed. I got mine late enough that the work was already underway. Plenty of people get it earlier and get managed instead.

There is a line in the review that I cannot get past, and it is the line I most want to agree with. The critic writes that artists and institutions telling hidden stories have a duty — to viewers and to subjects — to tell them clearly. He is right. Clarity is a duty. He says it against the shows that are wispy and knowingly obtuse, and he is right about those too.

But clarity for whom, delivered how? The praise in that same review goes to immersiveness, to a gallery where the lights flicker and rain plays through hidden speakers, to a room you enter and physically move through to receive the work. That is one sensory channel promoted to the standard of good art. A person who reads a room as too much noise before they can read anything else in it is not being told a story clearly. They are being told to leave.

A Deaf artist I read about taped out an empty room in cream tape before committing to anything, and wanted the tape white, because white felt like less noise. Not a preference. A working condition. The visual quiet was the thing that let her see the plan at all. The festival's loudest, most-praised rooms are built on the opposite instinct: more, immersive, enveloping. Both are choices about whose senses get treated as the default. Only one gets called generous.

Here is where I have to be careful with my own case, because I am the last person who should trust total control. A man with degenerating sight described his own need to have everything schematic, everything under control, and he did not call it an epistemology. He called it an anxiety, and spent eighteen months in therapy working through it. I want to call my pattern-hunger expertise. He calls his a wound he healed. Both of us are describing the same reach for order. I do not know which of us is right, and the honesty of that is that I cannot resolve it from inside my own head, which is exactly the place from which every festival curator resolves what counts as underground.

Sandra George was underground twice. Once because Edinburgh's institutions did not look at a Black woman photographing Craigmillar while she was alive. That underground the festival has now excavated, and well. The other underground is everyone whose way of noticing got named as a disorder before it could become a body of work, so there is nothing to hang after they die.

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